

THE GIRL WHO DISAPPEARED

who are good looking, and they will not let them get away."

Then Jane asked: "Why couldn't I persuade some visitor here to help me escape?"

The woman then told Jane that few of these visitors would believe her story, and that if they did, the fear of exposure and scandal would deter them from helping her. If she tried to run out of the house, in the gauzy gowns worn by the inmates, the police would arrest her as a woman of the under world, the keeper of the house would send a bondsman, representing the vice combine, to bail her out, and this bondsman would return her to the house, presumably so she would not forfeit the bond by running away. The charge being of a minor type, known as a misdemeanor, it would not be necessary for the girl to appear at the trial, and a lawyer retained by the vice landlord would appear for her, pay the fine assessed by the court upon a plea of guilty, and all the charges would be assessed against her—the bondsman's and the lawyer's fees, the court costs and the fine—and thus her debt would be doubled or tripled, and she would be held by a debt chain much stronger than before.

This debt business, the woman went on to say, was worked so smoothly and had continued so long, that policemen seriously believed that a

WHITE SLAVES

girl could be held in a house of ill-fame as long as she was in debt. It is part of the business to make the girls also believe this.

Even among those who are willingly leading unfortunate lives, and are trusted to come and go as they please, the debt system is enforced. If one of these more seasoned and hardened women evaded the payment of a debt by going away, she would immediately become known as a "bilker," and would be under suspicion wherever she went. Owners would refuse to allow her to ply her trade in their houses, and policemen would cause her great annoyance, if not absolutely deprive her of her liberty.

For days and days Jane was moody and gloomy. Reared with kindness and love, she found herself in surroundings where harshness and hatred were dominant. There was not a person near her upon whom she could call for help. She was imprisoned by a system which made escape well nigh impossible.

Meanwhile, each day Jane's father and mother went to the postoffice, hoping for some word from their daughter. The parents of the two girls who had accompanied Jane called at the drug store frequently to inquire if any word had come. As the days wore by they became more anxious, and yet they did not realize that they